

TEACHING PLAN –COM141

Faculty-Centre for Academic Development

Department-Communication and Study Skills Unit

Course/Module Title and Code-Communication and Academic Literacy for Science - COM 141

Credits - 12

NCQF LEVEL – 5

Type- Compulsory

Semester-1

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Course Synopsis

This course is designed to introduce science students to the concepts of communication, and Academic and Information literacy skills at the University of Botswana. Students will consider the contextual use of language in academic settings and develop their skills and competencies in listening and reading a variety of texts for a variety of purposes in Science. The Information Literacy skills are intended to solidify the use of information access tools for learning and research.

Learning Outcomes

- Apply the language skills of speaking, writing, reading and listening in all academic communication contexts relevant to the science discipline

- Apply principles of communication to both academic and social situations
- Develop and apply appropriate search strategies to locate information sources that match their needs
- Apply and demonstrate ethical and responsible use of information
- Develop and apply critical thinking skills in different situations
- Write academic texts that are fluent, accurate and appropriate to the scientific discipline
- Develop the ability to use appropriate oral discourse structures in order to participate in discussions.

Week and dates	Module / Course Learning Outcomes	Specific Learning Outcomes	Subject Matter/Content	Teaching Activities (develop lesson plan from this with intro, development, conclusion and evaluation)	Assessment Activities
Weeks 1-2 11/08/2025 – 22/08/2025 (6HRS)	• Apply the language skills of speaking, writing, reading and listening in all academic communication contexts relevant	• To communicate and respond to communication effectively	Module 1: INTRODUCTION TO UNIVERSITY LEARNING • Understanding the Culture of Higher Education • Orientation and library tour	• Lectures • Class discussions • Small group discussions • Pair work	- Oral submissions on the best ways to learn in the university - Discussions around the best ways to be motivated for learning. - Pair presentations on

	to the science discipline • Apply principles of communication to both academic and social situations		• Personal and academic goal development -motivation (intrinsic and extrinsic) • Personal learning style - Study habits - Time management - Personal organisation - Class attendance		the best ways to use the library to achieve learning goals.
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Week 3-4 25/08/2025 to 05/09/2025 (6 Hours)	• Apply principles of communication to both academic and social situations	• Select an appropriate medium to communicate ideas • Explain the key components of the communication process. • Identify some typical problems that can arise in the communication process • Demonstrate how to overcome barriers to effective communication	Module 2: COMMUNICATION IN ACADEMIC CONTEXTS The communication process Definition: Communication • The communication process • Modes of Communication in academic contexts: Oral (e.g. lecture), written (e.g. tests, lab reports), Computer Mediated Communication • (CMC) e.g. e-Learning • Factors and Barriers to effective communication	Lecture/tutorial sessions Research (Reading tasks) Class and group discussions Role play/simulation Group / pair work activities	- Discussion forum (in Moodle) - Impromptu quizzes in class - Oral discussion in class - Analysis of sample communicative events based on video samples watched.
Week 5 08/09/2025 to 12/09/2025 (3 Hours)	• Apply and demonstrate ethical and	• Use information technology to enhance their communication skills	Information sources and their organization • Differences between scholarly and non-	-Lectures/Tutorial sessions - Research (reading tasks) -Class and group discussions	-Tour and observation of the UB Library - Oral discussions in class based on

	responsible use of information		scholarly information sources • Formal and informal information sources • The role of scientific and indigenous knowledge in scholarly research • Differences between books, journals, databases, magazines, reports, web content, newspapers and social media • Organisation of information: class numbers, subject, physical arrangement Matching information needs to relevant information sources • Searching for and accessing information from sources e.g. OPAC and other databases	-Role play/simulation -Group / pair work activities	outcome of library tour - Written assignment on how to use information sources for academic work.
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Week 6 15/09/2025 to 19/09/2025 (3 Hours)	• Apply the language skills of speaking and listening in all academic communication contexts relevant to the science discipline	• Apply the language skills of speaking and listening in all academic communication contexts • Listen and respond to communication of others in classroom situations • Participate in and contribute to discussions, clarifying and interrogating ideas, developing and supporting arguments.	Module 3: LISTENING AND SPEAKING IN ACADEMIC CONTEXTS Listening skills • Listening during lectures - Active versus passive listening - Recognizing discourse markers during lectures - Recognizing non – verbal cues	-Lecture/tutorial sessions -Class and group discussions - Oral presentations -Research on how to use note taking techniques to take note from oral sources (reading activities)	CA 1(16 and 17 September 2025) Scope of task to be communicated
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Week 7 and 8 22/09/2025 to 03/10/2025 (6 Hours)	Apply the language skills of speaking and listening in all academic communication contexts relevant to the science discipline	- Apply the language skills of speaking and listening in all academic communication contexts relevant to the science discipline - Listen and respond to communication of others in classroom situations	Note taking from oral sources (lectures, tutorials, presentations, audio-video) - Importance of taking notes - Techniques for effective note taking (mind mapping, concept mapping, outlines, Cornell,) - Strategies for taking notes e.g. Abbreviations, use of symbols, short phrases.	- Lectures/tutorials - Using note taking techniques to take note from oral sources - Individual practice on note taking - Oral presentations	Listening to a sampled audio/video presentation and taking notes of the essential ideas from it (individual task).
05/10/2025 or 12/10/2025					CA2 Scope of task to be communicated
Week 9 and 10 06/10/2025 to 17/10/2025 (6 Hours)	Develop the ability to use appropriate oral discourse structures in	- Use information technology to enhance communication skills - Give an oral presentation in	Speaking skills - Planning an oral presentation - Delivering a presentation - Effective use using audio / visual aids	- Lecture/tutorial sessions - Class and group discussions - Watch and discuss speaking video samples - individual mini speaking presentations, etc.	- mini speaking assignments in pairs - analysis of academic speaking events - Question and answer session on

	order to participate in discussions. discipline	class using effective delivery strategies.	Giving and receiving feedback Verbal vs Non-Verbal Communication		delivering effective in-class presentations. Assignments on the role of different modes of oral presentations
Week 11 20/10/2025 to 24/10/2025 (3 Hours)	- Apply the language skill of reading in all academic communication contexts relevant to the science discipline - Develop and apply critical thinking skills in different situations	- Use various tools for informational or expository reading - Develop strategies for effective note-making. - Read, interpret and critique written texts. - Read, interpret and critiques infographics.	Module 4 READING FOR ACADEMIC PURPOSES Purposes and techniques of reading - Purposes for reading - Reading techniques for academic purposes - skimming, scanning, prediction, study reading, SQ3R - Text organization features (headings, sub-headings, paragraphs) - Interpreting graphic information.	- Lectures/tutorials - Class discussions - Group Work on assigned texts for reading and note making - Group Presentations	- Reading sampled academic texts in class to: (1) be able to talk about how the text is organised (2) retrieve its salient ideas, (3) and the relevant details of the text (in-class discussion) - A similar individual task to be done as a take-away written assignment.

Week 12 27/10/2025 to 31/10/2025 (3 Hours)	• Apply and demonstrate ethical and responsible use of information	• Describe different criteria used for evaluation of information sources and platforms • Evaluate information sources for currency, authority, authenticity, relevance, objectivity, scope and accuracy	Evaluation of information sources • Criteria for evaluation of information sources and platforms • Critical and analytical reading • Evaluating information sources for currency, authority, authenticity, relevance, objectivity, scope, accuracy and level of evidence.	Lectures/tutorials Class Discussions Demonstrations Group tasks	- Group Reading activities to identify the use of sources - Group discussion on the effectiveness of the use of academic sources - A take-away reading assignment on the functions of sources in academic texts read
Week 13 03/11/2025 to 07/11/2025 (3 Hours)	• Apply and demonstrate ethical and responsible use of information	• Use the information found ethically to satisfy the information need • Identify the components of a scientific reference	Note making from written sources - Paraphrasing - Summarizing - Introduction to legal and ethical use of information - Plagiarism - Copyright	- Class discussions - Group discussions - Practical	-Pair reading task from which notes are to be made for class discussion -Pair reading task from which the use of sources is to be discussed in class. Individual reading assignments from

			- Citation: in-text and end of text citations - Referencing: components of a scientific reference		which summaries are to be written.
02/11/2025 or 09/11/2025					CA 3 Scope of task to be communicated.

Recommended Reading List

1. Moore S., Neville, C., Murphy, M., & Connolly, C. (2010). *The Ultimate Study Skills Handbook*. Mc Graw Hill: Open University Press.
2. Bovee, C.L. & Thill, J.V. (2008). *Communication Today*. (10th ed.) New Jersey: Pearson Hall
3. Mhundwa, P. H., Magogwe, J. M., Kalane, M. (2008). *Developing Communication and Study Skills*, Gaborone: Collegium Publishers.
4. Steinberg, S. 2006. *An Introduction to Communication Studies*. Cape Town: JUTA
5. Stanton, N. 2009. *Mastering communication*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan
6. Goatly, A. and Hiradhar, P. 2016. *Critical reading and writing in the digital age: An introductory coursebook*. London: Routledge